

Improving Documentation Practices for Academic Advisors

Meet Sammy.

- First-year Biology student
- First-Generation college student
- Wants to become a doctor
- Just finished her first semester

Advising focus:

- At risk of being placed on academic probation
- Needs help adjusting spring schedule



Sammy has met with multiple advisors.

Advisor #1's Note:

"Met with Sammy. Discussed classes. Student will follow up."

Advisor #2's Note:

"Thanks for meeting with me today! We reviewed the academic probation policy (which can be found [here](#)). We decided to remove Hist 101 from your spring schedule so you have more time to focus on your heavy bio and chem classes. I'm submitting a referral to UMKC Central – someone will be contacting you shortly to discuss SAP. Don't forget to sign up for [tutoring](#)! Reach out if you have any other questions."

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this session, you will be able to:

- Explain the importance of effective advising notes
- Distinguish between effective and ineffective examples
- Identify FERPA and other compliance issues
- Apply these criteria when reviewing or writing notes



Why Do Effective Advising Notes Matter?

1) **Advising notes are resources**

- Students can refer back to the notes to remember what was discussed
- Reviewing previous notes can help you prepare for your next meeting with the student
- Other student support personnel can access notes when assisting students

2) Advising notes help support continuity of care

- There's a lot of turnover in advising! Reviewing detailed notes helps new advisors pick up where the previous advisor left off
 - Prevents students from having to repeat themselves, which improves students perceptions of advising
- Sometimes students approach a different advisor hoping for a different answer to a question
 - Minimizes the possibility of giving conflicting advice, which reduces confusion for students and advisors

3) Advising notes protect YOU!

- Advising notes provide evidence of communication and follow-up.
- Can clarify misunderstandings when students escalate concerns.
- Professional, factual notes demonstrate that policies and options were explained clearly.

What else?

In your breakout rooms, please discuss other personal motivations for writing effective notes. You can also talk about times when you've seen the benefit of an effective note, or when an ineffective note caused confusion or created risk.

If every advising note meets shared UMKC standards, advisors will reduce miscommunication, improve student outcomes, and strengthen retention initiatives.

Advising Notes: Do's and Don'ts

DO:

Summarize key items discussed: course recommendations, advice, referrals, action items, etc.

- "Because of your interest in chemistry, we added Chem 211/L and Math 110 to your schedule. I recommend taking fewer credits this spring so you can really focus on these heavier courses but you felt confident enrolling in 17. I made a referral to UMKC Central to discuss scholarship options so someone should reach out soon! Don't forget to take the Civics exam asap."

DON'T:

Summarize every detail

- "You mentioned you're going to the men's basketball game tonight; that sounds so fun!"

OR

Fail to include necessary level of detail

- "Chose spring classes. Cashiers hold."

Advising Notes: Do's and Don'ts

DO:

Be objective

- "Student is concerned that major isn't a good fit."

DON'T:

Be subjective

- "Student doesn't seem like a good trumpet player."

Advising Notes: Do's and Don'ts

DO:

Record referrals made

- "Referred to Counseling Services."

AND:

Use general or coded language for sensitive material

- "Student related a personal situation impacting academic performance this semester."

DON'T:

Include details about sensitive referrals or circumstances

- "Student reported being assaulted; referred to Title IX and Counseling Services."

Advising Notes: Do's and Don'ts

DO:

Use clear, professional language

- "We reviewed your degree audit and confirmed that you're on track to complete your minor."

DON'T:

Use informal or vague language

- "We went over the stuff you need for your minor and you should be all good there."

While optional, a template can help make sure you don't leave out any important details:

Hi NAME,

It was great meeting with you today! Here's a summary of what we discussed:

Enrollment: (list classes, number of credits, recommendations, etc.)

Holds:

Referrals:

Petitions:

Student action items:

Advisor action items:

Important upcoming dates:

Other information:

Please reach out if you have any questions!

You can use this template or create your own!

Adapting Notes for Different Advising Contexts

Some advising contexts may require slightly different details to be included in the advising note.

What details may need to be included for...

- A transfer student?
- A graduating senior?
- A student on Academic Probation?

Transfer Student

More background information on student and their goals:

- “You’re an incoming Bio BS student intending to pursue dentistry. Because of this, we added the pre-dental track and the chemistry minor (since you’ll be completing those classes anyway!). Based on the tentative plan we built today, you should be able to graduate in Spring 2028, which aligned with the timeline you envisioned.”

General resource links:

- Parking operations, student ID office, academic support and mentoring, Financial Aid, etc.

Graduating Senior

Clear explanation of what classes they need to graduate:

- “Psych 316 is specifically required for your degree, but you can swap out Psych 407 or 323 for any other 300/400-level Psychology classes.”

Graduation requirements:

- “Make sure to submit your application for graduation ASAP. We also need your MCC transcript with your calc credit before May or your degree will not be awarded.”

Student on Academic Probation

Summary of Academic Probation policy:

- “You need to earn at least a 2.0 GPA for your term GPA this spring in order to continue taking classes here. If you raise your cumulative GPA to a 2.0 or higher, you will no longer be on Academic Probation. If you do not earn at least a 2.0 GPA for the spring term, you may be dismissed.”

Links to academic support resources:

- Success Coaches, tutoring, SI sessions, etc.

Effective notes are:

Clear

Professional

Objective

Concise

Complete

Consistent

Let's compare some examples!

As you read these notes, think about the following questions:

- Does the note clearly summarize the meeting?
- Would the note make sense to someone who wasn't at the meeting?
- Does the note use professional language?
- Does it leave out personal judgments or assumptions?
- Is the information in the note accurate (university policies, deadlines, or requirements)?

(Pull up examples in Connect)

Your turn!

Take some time to assess the sample notes given to you using the provided checklist. Using what you've learned, classify them as effective or ineffective, and then rewrite the ineffective notes!

FERPA and UMKC Note-Taking Policies

Quick Review:

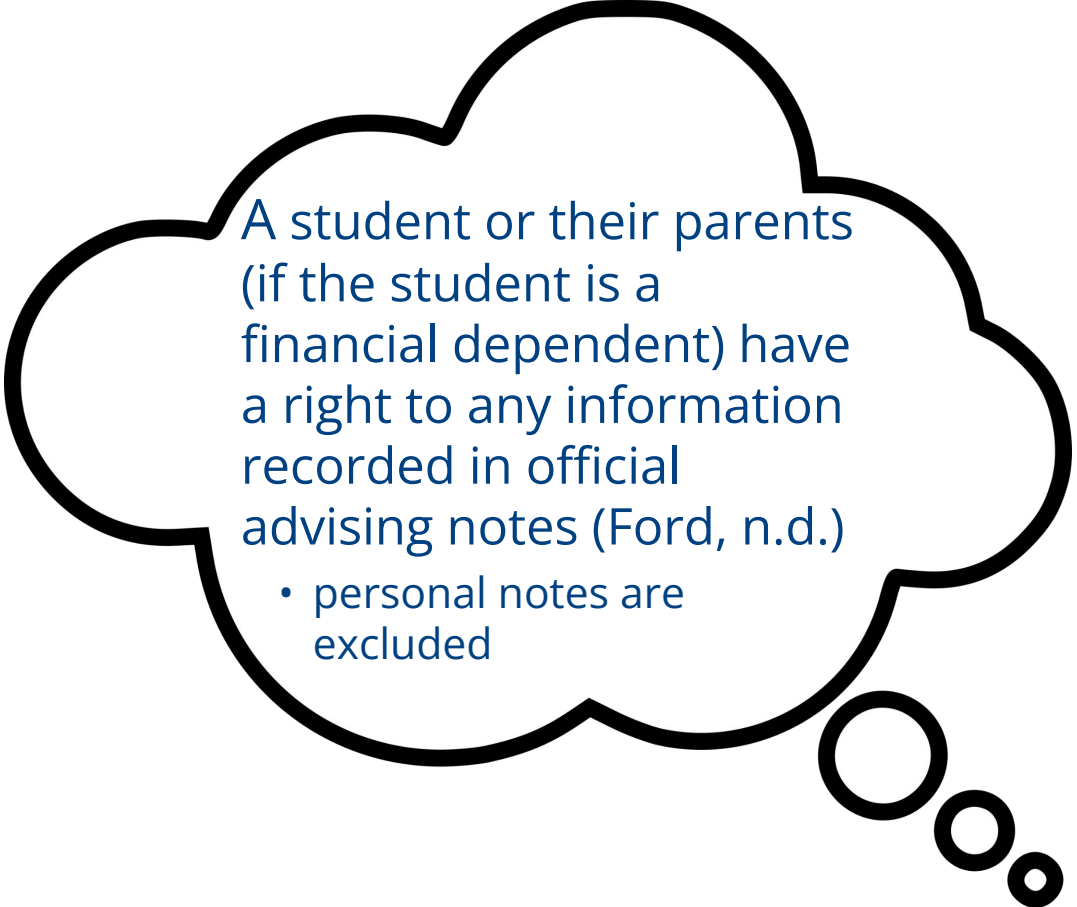
- ☒ Summarize key items discussed
 - ☒ course recommendations, advice, referrals, action items, etc.
- ☒ Be objective
- ☒ Record referrals and use general language for sensitive materials
- ☒ Clear, professional language

How to record information?

- 1) State factual information
- 2) Avoid judgement and bias
- 3) Sensitive information - when in doubt leave it out

Directory information is not protected under FERPA.

(i.e. email addresses, academic major, awards, class standing, student ID numbers, etc.) - (U.S. Department of Education, Student Privacy Policy Office, 2023)



A student or their parents
(if the student is a
financial dependent) have
a right to any information
recorded in official
advising notes (Ford, n.d.)

- personal notes are
excluded

“Under the health and safety exception, advisors may share information from an education record (e.g., a troubling email) if doing so is necessary to protect the health and safety of that student or others.”

(NACADA, n.d.)



Example 1:

You mentioned wanting to change your degree because the program was too hard and you are struggling to keep up with the load. We talked about how the degree you enrolled in was different than you thought. So we reviewed your after graduation goals and did some career searching. You decided to do some research on your own and we will meet again in a couple of weeks.

DISCUSS

What edits should be made and why?

Example 2:

Two weeks ago, you were in a car accident and were admitted to the hospital with a concussion and a broken leg. You are having severe headaches that are affecting your class attendance and completing your course work. I recommended that you contact the disabilities office on campus for temporary assistance. You can reach the disabilities office by email at disabilities@university.edu or calling (444)456-7859.

DISCUSS

What edits should be made and why?

Example 3:

Thank you for stopping in today!

You mentioned having some recent personal challenges and we discussed taking a break for Spring 2026 semester.

I'll reach out to you halfway through Spring semester to check in.

DISCUSS

What edits should be made and why?



IT'S YOUR TURN

mark the problem areas
and rewrite the note.

Example A

You stopped by my office today to discuss courses for next semester. You failed your chemistry midterm. Your professor said you were lazy and don't try hard enough. We discussed your past and current academic status and personal challenges you are currently facing.

You are dropping chemistry before the last day to drop deadline on the 5th and will enroll in Physics 101 next semester for your science requirement.

Example B

Your participation has been inconsistent this semester. You shared that your parents are getting divorced and you are really struggling emotionally. Since it is early enough in the semester, we discussed moving you to part-time student status and dropping two of your current courses by the 8th (the 50% refund deadline) to reduce your stress and keep you on target for the same graduation date. You will reach out if the two courses become problematic and we need to make further adjustments.

Example C

With Spring early registration approaching, I reached out about returning to school next semester. You mentioned that your therapist thinks you are not ready to return to class. We reassessing your academic plan to include a gap year.

You will reach out if you are ready to return before that year is up.

Example D

You have been struggling in class for the past two semesters. You mentioned having a disability and refuse to use accommodations. Without the accommodations, you might lose his scholarships or will be placed on probation.

If you change your mind, the disabilities office can be reached by email at disabilities@university.edu or calling (444)456-7859.

Example E

You shared that your financial aid was revoked because your dad lost his job. Your goal is to continue with school and find alternative aid. I've attached a list of financial resources and scholarships. Let me know if you have any questions or need any assistance applying.

Let's get real!



[insert video of a Sammy mock academic advising scenario]

What would the advising note look like for this scenario?

[insert class created advising note]

Now it's your turn!

1

You will be split into breakout rooms and given a link to a video.



2

Watch your room's advising scenario video.



3

For the first 5 minutes, create your own advising note for the scenario.



4

The next 5 minutes, collaborate with your team to create one advising note.



Group #1's video

[insert Sammy advising
video #1]

[Group #1 will share their note here]

Rubric Comparison

Completeness:

Is there a summary of the discussion?
Are follow-up steps listed?
Are any referrals listed?
Are all relevant details listed?
Is it consistent yet thorough?

Clarity and tone:

Is it professional?
Does it use student-centered objective language?
Is it free of jargon?
Is it easily understood by advisors or administrators?

Accuracy and Compliance:

Does it represent the conversation while compliant with FERPA and institutional policy?
Are there any errors in content?

Actionability:

Does it clearly state next steps for the student and advisor?
Does it provide adequate context for follow-up by others?

Referral and Resource Documentation:

Does it include properly documented referrals?
Does it include relevant context for support?

Group #2's video

[insert Sammy advising
video #2]

[Group #2 will share their note here]

Rubric Comparison

Completeness:

Is there a summary of the discussion?
Are follow-up steps listed?
Are any referrals listed?
Are all relevant details listed?
Is it consistent yet thorough?

Clarity and tone:

Is it professional?
Does it use student-centered objective language?
Is it free of jargon?
Is it easily understood by advisors or administrators?

Accuracy and Compliance:

Does it represent the conversation while compliant with FERPA and institutional policy?
Are there any errors in content?

Actionability:

Does it clearly state next steps for the student and advisor?
Does it provide adequate context for follow-up by others?

Referral and Resource Documentation:

Does it include properly documented referrals?
Does it include relevant context for support?

Group #3's video

[insert Sammy advising
video #3]

[Group #3 will share their note here]

Rubric Comparison

Completeness:

Is there a summary of the discussion?
Are follow-up steps listed?
Are any referrals listed?
Are all relevant details listed?
Is it consistent yet thorough?

Clarity and tone:

Is it professional?
Does it use student-centered objective language?
Is it free of jargon?
Is it easily understood by advisors or administrators?

Accuracy and Compliance:

Does it represent the conversation while compliant with FERPA and institutional policy?
Are there any errors in content?

Actionability:

Does it clearly state next steps for the student and advisor?
Does it provide adequate context for follow-up by others?

Referral and Resource Documentation:

Does it include properly documented referrals?
Does it include relevant context for support?

Group #4's video

[insert Sammy advising
video #4]

[Group #4 will share their note here]

Rubric Comparison

Completeness:

Is there a summary of the discussion?
Are follow-up steps listed?
Are any referrals listed?
Are all relevant details listed?
Is it consistent yet thorough?

Clarity and tone:

Is it professional?
Does it use student-centered objective language?
Is it free of jargon?
Is it easily understood by advisors or administrators?

Accuracy and Compliance:

Does it represent the conversation while compliant with FERPA and institutional policy?
Are there any errors in content?

Actionability:

Does it clearly state next steps for the student and advisor?
Does it provide adequate context for follow-up by others?

Referral and Resource Documentation:

Does it include properly documented referrals?
Does it include relevant context for support?

Final Thoughts

Remember!

Effective notes are:

Clear

Professional

Objective

Concise

Complete

Consistent

Do's and Don'ts of Advising Notes

DO

- Summarize key items
- Be objective
- Record referrals
- Use general or coded language for sensitive topics
- Be clear and professional
- Adapt notes for different contexts

DON'T

- Summarize every detail
- Fail to include necessary details
- Be subjective
- Include sensitive information
- Use informal or vague language

Reflect

Write a short reflection (approx 200 words) using the guiding questions below

- How do the strategies presented in this course align with or differ from your current documentation practice?
- What strategies presented here will you implement in your documentation process?
- How do you envision these strategies will impact your documentation or overall advising practice?

Share

In your breakout rooms,
share at least one takeaway
or strategy you plan to
implement in your work.

Thank you!



References:

- NACADA: The Global Community for Academic Advising. (n.d.). *FERPA overview*.
<https://nacada.ksu.edu/Resources/Clearinghouse/View-Articles/FERPA-overview.aspx>
- U.S. Department of Education, Student Privacy Policy Office. (2023, March 8). An eligible student guide to the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) (SPPO-23-01).
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